Omen Concept Design

1 Sweet Dream

Setting: Indoors

Background

After several rounds of hypnosis, the daughter of the country's leading psychology professor still dies by suicide. A fuller backstory is to be developed. After a long period of despair, he gradually loses his grip on reality and forgets that she has died. Having read about a perfect dream world, he becomes obsessed with finding a treatment that can truly heal her. He begins experimenting on his patients, trying to construct a flawless dream. His dreams become increasingly lifelike, and more and more people in the city fall asleep. Eventually, the entire city joins him inside the perfect dream he has created.

Key: His daughter's crayon drawing of the two of them.

Three Omens: A brass pocket watch with a photograph of the professor and his daughter inside the cover; a metronome; a spinning top.

The player intrudes on the dream, disrupting the perfect life the professor shares with his daughter. He wants to banish the player from it forever.

Mini-boss: A teddy bear.

Final boss: The professor and his daughter, fought together.

Enemies: Clusters of building blocks, stationery, and musical notes.

Final Boss Visual Concept

A small, thin child in a pink-and-white checked dress, with pigtails and a teddy bear in her arms. She looks clean and adorable, with the professor's spectral figure pressed closely behind her. The scene begins with a bright palette and can become increasingly dim, decayed, and fragmented as the fight progresses.

References: Inception (2010), The Great Hypnotist (2014), and Hypnotisören (2012).

2 Misty Garden

Setting: Indoors and outdoors

Background

Overnight, a classical garden appears in the middle of a bustling city. Outside, the sky is clear; above the garden, a thin mist never lifts. Curious visitors approach and mysteriously disappear. Only a faint echo drifts out: No loud noises. Do not touch the artifacts. Do not feed the animals...

Key: A painted scroll.

Three Omens: A porcelain vase, a potted plant, and an incense burner.

Mini-boss: The stone lions at the courtyard gate.

Final boss: The two dragons from the painted scroll.

Enemies: Fish, bats, and turtles reimagined as object-like creatures with a weirdcore aesthetic.

Final Boss Visual Concept

A Chinese ink-painting aesthetic. Both bosses have dragon heads, human bodies, dragon claws, and scales. One carries a long saber and wears gold-and-silver Chinese armor with a large gold section across the chest. The other carries a jian, a rigid Chinese striking weapon, and wears black Chinese armor with a belt.

References: Arknights (2019) and Inside the Backroom (2022).

3 Fairy Tale World

Setting: Indoors and outdoors

Background

He is the kingdom's most celebrated writer. Parents are mocked if their children do not own one of his fairy-tale books. As he writes more stories, his fame grows. Gradually, however, children, parents, and everyone else begin to say that something is missing from his new work. His stories are no longer as interesting as before. Readers abandon him. Even without a new fairy-tale author to replace him, children would rather read obscure old novels than open another of his books.

What is missing? he wonders. He cannot understand why neither he nor his stories are welcome anymore. He begins writing obsessively. Every sheet of parchment in his house fills with revisions. When his ink runs dry and his paper runs out, he still feels that his work lacks something it once had. He bites his finger and writes in blood on the walls and floor, until words cover every surface. Despair overwhelms him. What is missing? He still cannot understand. He cuts his wrist and writes the truest fairy tale of his life.

Development note: If this backstory is expanded, explore the contrast between his life before and after losing his popularity, and why his work fell out of favor. Possible themes include self-esteem and personal charisma.

Key: A fairy-tale book whose cover still looks new, while its pages have yellowed and begun to decay.

Three Omens: A fountain pen with a broken nib that keeps producing ink from its dried-out ink sac; a parchment manuscript covered in revisions; an overturned oil lamp with its spilled oil congealed.

The player enters his fairy-tale world. The writer blames the player for everything that made his work unpopular and vows to erase them from his world to restore his reputation.

Mini-boss: A fairy-tale prince riding a white horse.

Final boss: The writer.

Enemies: Wolves, hunters, wizards, elves, and giants. I think any creature commonly found in fairy tales could work.

Level Visual Concept

Begin with a bright fairy-tale art style. As the player finds more Omens, the environment can gradually fall into ruin. I want the final boss fight to take place in the writer's house, with blood-written words covering the walls and floor. The space is decayed and dirty, in dark browns and grays, with colors and textures resembling damp, rotting wood. The atmosphere is dim and sinister.

Final Boss Visual Concept

The writer looks weak but stands perfectly upright, holding a pen and paper. His clothes are dirty yet orderly: dark brown stripes or checks, a flat cap, glasses, and leather shoes. Several bleeding wounds are visible on exposed skin.